Attachment A



2027 Board Legislative Principles

The Portland Public Schools (PPS) Board Intergovernmental Relations Committee presents these legislative principles to provide a strategic framework for the Board's engagement in the 2027 legislative session. Our primary objective is to advocate for policies and resources that directly support the district's core mission: ensuring every student has access to a rigorous education within a safe, welcoming, and inclusive environment. These principles reflect our commitment to fostering school communities where all students—regardless of background—possess the resources they need to learn, belong, and thrive.

Today, for PPS and school districts across Oregon that mission is at risk as schools are navigating an increasingly complex landscape of systemic challenges. Persistent funding shortfalls, exacerbated by inflationary pressures and the rising cost of essential services, are further complicated by the heightened social and emotional needs of our students. Additionally, broader community instability—driven by reductions in federal support programs like SNAP and Medicaid, alongside intensified immigration enforcement—places an unsustainable burden on our students, educators, and school leadership. Together, these factors are placing an enormous burden on schools and present threats to core student service and ongoing school stability. The PPS Board is committed to working alongside state leaders to address these root challenges and place schools and Oregon on a path to becoming the best in the nation.

As we work towards building the legislative agenda for the 2027 session, our work will be guided by the following priorities:

- **Provide Adequate Funding to Meet Students Needs:** State education funding continues to fall behind rising operational costs, leaving Portland Public Schools (PPS) with a projected $65 million shortfall for the 2027–28 school year. The state must partner with school districts to provide sufficient funding to prevent disruptions to classroom instruction and core student services. Funding must be available to help school districts shoulder the weight of unexpected cost increases including PERS, services for students with disabilities, and significantly increasing expenses.
- **Support for Students with Disabilities:** We seek to ensure adequate funding and support for students with disabilities.

    - **Lifting the Special Education Cap:** The state funding formula provides an additional 1.0 weighting for students with disabilities, but caps that additional funding at 11% of a district's total student population. However, Oregon's 11% reimbursement threshold falls far short of actual needs, as the state average is 15% and PPS's special education population is 17%. As a result, districts serving higher proportions of students with disabilities must divert local general funds to cover the growing deficit.
    - **Fully Fund the High Cost Disability Account:** The state currently reimburses special education costs for students with disabilities that exceed $30,000, but chronic underfunding of the grant program leaves districts to absorb the majority of the financial burden. To protect local school budgets, the state must significantly increase appropriations for this account.
- **Strengthen Educator Preparation Programs:** Strengthen educator preparation programs to ensure that new teachers are fully equipped to serve students with complex learning needs. This includes ensuring that new teachers are trained in evidence-based practices to effectively support students who are learning English and students who are struggling to learn to read. The state legislature can accomplish this by:
    - Codifying standards for literacy instruction developed by the Early Literacy Educator Preparation Council;
    - Expanding funding for Educator Preparation Programs (EPPs) to strengthen program capacity;
    - Bolstering certification programs to ensure that all new teachers in Oregon and teachers from out of state demonstrate proficiency in instructional delivery.

- **Defend Against Unfunded Mandates:** Ensure every new administrative or legal requirement placed on school districts is fully supported by state funding. Amid existing budget shortfalls, unfunded requirements force districts to divert resources directly away from students and classrooms. The state legislature must also examine existing mandates to identify and eliminate costly burdens that compromise instructional funding.
    - **Public Employee Retirement System (PERS):** Currently, school districts are obligated to contribute to the retirement pensions of both current and retired employees. Funding for the pension system comes directly out of the State School Fund—the same source that supports core student services. As policymakers work to evaluate how Oregon's school funding compares to other states, PERS obligations distort the picture because they are included in those funding formulas. To clarify how much state funding actually directly supports student services versus pension obligations, the state should examine options to better separate and manage PERS costs.